

Is AI still bad for the environment if locally hosted with solar?

Posted by u/MoonRum • • 0 points • 11 comments

To get straight to the point, I recently saw someone claim that their use of generative AI should be given a pass, because they claim they allegedly only host their slop locally and only use their home solar power setup to run it, therefore having 0 negative environmental impact. I'm highly skeptical of this, but I was hoping people more educated on the finer details of the topic could help me better understand the situation and suss out the validity of these claims.

Comments

u/Cwaghack • 1 points • 2026-03-31 21:51 UTC

It's about as neutral for the environment as things could feasibly be. We all do countless other needless things in our day to day lives that is worse

u/Scienceandpony • 1 points • 2026-03-27 21:07 UTC

Running it locally wouldn't be problem, though I assume the hardcore antis would claim guilt by association as it's the training that went into creating the model, rather than querying the finished product, that is energy intensive/water intensive/immoral/whatever. The whole idea of "sending a text on your iphone doesn't hurt anyone, but the materials to make it were mined by slave labor".

One could argue that that damage is already done and one's use of the product after the fact has no impact on that one way or the other. Me not eating a burger does not unkill the cow, or undo all the environmental damage that already occurred across the entire beef industry supply chain. Others would say that engaging with it at all still makes you complicit in supporting the industry, particularly if you are paying any money for it. There's counterarguments of there being no ethical consumption under capitalism and threshold effects rendering individual consumer actions insignificant (you turning your light on or off does not translate to the coal plant stepping generation up or down in response).

And if you were locally running opensource AI that you didn't pay a dime for, it would stand to reason that those "financially supporting the industry" arguments shouldn't apply, the same way you're not really supporting J.K. Rowling's transphobic crusade if you pirate Harry Potter media. But the hardcore antis aren't running off rational arguments. It's predominantly emotional appeals and tribalism, with AI technology as a whole presented as an inherently evil force that spiritually corrupts anyone who engages with it.

u/ea_nasir_official_ • 1 points • 2026-03-27 20:12 UTC

no. the training was likely somewhat bad, although with chinese llms lesser so as they were trained using mostly air cooled consumer hardware that they modify to add more vram due to the difficulty of getting data center gpus. Also the model already exists, using it doesnt add more impact

u/ghostbustersgear • 1 points • 2026-03-27 20:10 UTC

It's a valid point, I think, but it's only part of the story. You can run some models cheaply and locally. However, those models were trained so they have an 'embedded' climate cost used to produce them.

It's like with any product really. You could live in a brand new house that is extremely energy efficient and has low carbon impact in its operation. However it also carries the 'embedded carbon' of all the materials, means, and methods that were used to produce it.

So a total environmental impact of a thing requires consideration for the lifecycle: how it was made, how it's operated (your friend's argument is here), how it's dismantled, how it might be recycled.

u/HashPandaNL • 1 points • 2026-03-28 02:14 UTC

>You can run some models cheaply and locally. However, those models were trained so they have an 'embedded' climate cost used to produce them.

The embedded climate cost is only relevant if you in one way or another fund/support the company the production of future models such that they have increased climate costs. If you simply download an open-source model, this is not relevant and so the embedded climate cost is effectively 0.

If you pay to download the AI model, that is a different story of course.

u/ghostbustersgear • 1 points • 2026-03-28 03:10 UTC

Hmm... I don't agree that it's not relevant or that clear cut. The energy used to make the thing was still used whether the thing is made available for free or not. There was an environmental cost (as well as time, labor, etc) to produce it.

I would also assert that downloads and usage are a form of support. Maybe you don't directly pay, but your usage contributes to its popularity and that could result in someone else deciding to donate or fund the development of the product. Maybe the author uses its download stats to justify/pursue funding, for example.

u/Ok-Box3576 • 4 points • 2026-03-27 20:08 UTC

"AI" itself isnt nesscary bad or good its just a thing ppl create and use.

Its environmental impact is just one aspect. And if an AI is fully powered by solar thats good and could potentially make it "ok".

What else does the AI do? Does it encourage parasocial relationships? Does it run ads/collect data without proper warnings?/does it kill ppl(military use)

u/Miserable-Whereas910 • 5 points • 2026-03-27 19:59 UTC

I mean, if they had those solar panels but weren't using AI, that energy would go into the grid and slightly reduce the amount of fossil fuels being used.

On the other hand, local models aren't typically using a gigantic amount of energy. More than average compute use, but pretty comparable to, say, gaming. They're really not what we should be focusing on when it comes to the environmental damage of AI: the big offenders are the models you can't run on consumer hardware.

u/Dack_Blick • 0 points • 2026-03-27 19:39 UTC

The overwhelming vast majority of things humans do are bad for the environment. Even those solar panels require mining for the resources, refining them, actually making the item, shipping it, etc.

The question is, how bad is it for the environment, WHEN COMPARED TO OTHER THINGS. And the moment you do that, all of AI's environmental damage becomes miniscule.

u/Petala-Puella • 2 points • 2026-03-27 20:00 UTC

That may be one of the worst excuses and off-topic replies I've heard in a long time...

u/MoonRum • 2 points • 2026-03-27 19:46 UTC

As I'm well aware. Not what I'm asking though.

u/MoonRum • 2 points • 2026-03-27 19:44 UTC

As I'm well aware. Not what I was asking about though.